By TOUCH DEN · November 11, 2026

Who Attacks and Why



Video 1 · The Real Attackers

Security Fundamentals · Section 4

In this video, you will learn:

- Why the "hooded hacker" picture is mostly wrong
- Script kiddies and opportunists
- Organized cybercrime and ransomware crews

The myth of the hooded hacker

Films show a lone genius breaking into a bank by typing fast. Real attackers look nothing like this.

- *Most attacks are **not** aimed at you personally: they are automated, sweeping the whole internet for any weak system.*
- *Many serious attackers are **organized groups**, run like businesses, not lone geniuses.*
- *Most break-ins use **ordinary weaknesses**: a reused password, an unpatched program, a convincing email.*

Believing the myth leads to defending against the wrong attacks.

Script kiddies and opportunists

- ***Script kiddies*** *use tools others built, without deep understanding. The tools are powerful, so the damage is real.*
- ***Opportunists*** *aren't after you specifically; they take any easy target. Most automated attacks are opportunistic, scanning millions of addresses for a known weakness.*

Defense: *basic security stops most of them. Update software, use strong unique passwords, don't expose needless services.*

Key lesson: *you don't need to be unbreakable, only* ***harder than the next target****.*

Cybercriminals and ransomware crews

The largest serious threat to most businesses: ***organized cybercrime****, run like an industry.*

- ***Ransomware-as-a-service:*** *some write the malware and rent it out; others break in; others launder money.*
- ***Double extortion:*** *they steal the data first, then lock it, so they can threaten to publish even if you have backups.*
- ***Motive:*** *money, directly. They pick targets by profit, not grudge.*

Defense: *defense in depth,* ***offline backups above all****, training, patching, MFA.*

Recap: the real attackers

- *Real attacks are mostly automated, opportunistic, and use ordinary weaknesses.*
- *Basic hygiene stops most opportunists: be harder than the next target.*
- *Organized ransomware crews are the biggest money threat; offline backups are the key defense.*

Next video: *insiders, hacktivists, and nation-states.*

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Video 2 · From Insiders to Nation-States

Security Fundamentals · Section 4

In this video, you will learn:

- Why insiders are a special threat
- Hacktivists
- Nation-states and APTs

Insiders

An **insider** already has legitimate access: an employee, contractor, or supplier. Dangerous because they're already inside your defenses.

- **Malicious:** abuse access on purpose, to steal, defraud, or out of anger.
- **Accidental:** cause harm by mistake, far more common, phishing, misconfiguration, a lost laptop.

Defense: least privilege, logging and monitoring, separation of duties, and a culture where people report mistakes instead of hiding them.

Hacktivists

***Hacktivist** = hacker + activist. They attack to make a political or social point.*

- ***Aim:** attention, not money, defacing a site, leaking documents, knocking a service offline in protest.*
- ***Skill:** varies, basic to capable.*
- ***Targets:** organizations they oppose.*

***Defense:** the fundamentals, plus extra care for public-facing systems and the ability to withstand a flood of traffic.*

Nation-states and APTs

*Government-funded teams. Their long campaigns are called **APTs**: Advanced Persistent Threats.*

- ***Advanced:** well-funded, highly skilled, sometimes using unknown weaknesses (**zero-days**).*
- ***Persistent:** they don't give up; they may hide for months or years.*
- ***Threat:** real intent and capability.*

***Motives:** espionage, sabotage, influence. **Defense:** you usually can't outspend a government, aim to be costly to hit, detect fast, and limit damage. Small firms are often hit as a **stepping-stone** to a bigger target.*

Recap: insiders to nation-states

- ***Insiders*** *are trusted and already inside; accidents outnumber malice. Least privilege and logging help.*
- ***Hacktivists*** *want attention; protect public-facing systems.*
- ***Nation-states / APTs*** *are skilled and persistent; detect fast and limit damage.*

Next video: *the motives behind it all, and what it means for how you defend.*

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Video 3 · Motives, and What It Means for You

Security Fundamentals · Section 4

In this video, you will learn:

- The four basic motives
- How to match attackers to your organization
- Why ordinary defenses go a long way

The basic motives

Knowing the motive predicts what an attacker wants and how they'll behave.

Motive	What they want	Typical attacker
Money	Payment, fraud, resold data	Cybercriminals, ransomware
Information	Secrets, designs, personal data	Nation-states, competitors
Disruption	Stop a service, cause chaos	Hacktivists, insiders
Belief	Make a point, gain attention	Hacktivists

*Most business attacks are about **money**.*

Know your threat model

Defend against the attackers you are actually likely to face.

Organization	*Likely attackers*
Small shop	*Opportunists, ransomware crews*
Hospital or bank	*The above + targeted criminals, fraud rings*
Government / defense	*The above + nation-states*
Everyone	***Insiders***

*Most attacks are opportunistic and use ordinary weaknesses, so **ordinary defenses stop most of them**.*

Recap: motives and defense

- *Four motives: money, information, disruption, belief. Most business attacks are money.*
- *Match your defenses to the attackers you'll really face; everyone faces insiders.*
- *You rarely need to be unbreakable, just harder than the next target, and quick to detect and recover.*

Next lesson: *the common attacks themselves, phishing, malware, and more.*